

DECIR LOS AÑOS Y LAS FECHAS

Saying years and dates out loud · 1995, 2026, el 8 de junio · Castilian / Valencia register · phonetics built in

01 The one idea to lock in first

Read it as ONE whole number: Spanish never splits a year into two halves the way English does. 1995 is not 'nineteen ninety-five'. It is one single number: mil novecientos noventa y cinco (literally 'one thousand nine hundred ninety-five').

So every year = thousands + hundreds + tens + units: you build it left to right in one breath: mil / novecientos / noventa / y cinco. Master the four building blocks below and you can say any year.

No 'in' contortions: 'in 1995' is simply en mil novecientos noventa y cinco. The en is the only extra word.

02 How to read the phonetics on this sheet

CAPITALS = the stressed syllable: say that syllable louder and longer. no-beh-THYEN-tos = stress on THYEN.

th = the Castilian lisp (ceceo): in Spain, c before e/i and the letter z are said like the 'th' in 'think'. cinco = THEEN-ko, doce = DO-theh. In Latin America this same sound is a plain 's' (see the traps box).

b stands for the Spanish v: v and b are the SAME soft sound in Spanish. novecientos starts no-beh-, veinte is BEYN-teh.

h = the throaty j/g: junio = HOO-nyo, the H is the rough sound at the back of the throat. (A plain Spanish h is always silent.)

03 Building block 1 - the thousands

Number	Spanish	Phonetic	Used for years like
1000	mil	meel	1066, 1492, 1995 (all start 'meel ...')
2000	dos mil	dos meel	2000, 2008, 2026 (all start 'dos meel ...')

Just 'mil', never 'un mil': the thousand on its own is plain mil. You do NOT say 'uno mil'. 1000 = mil, 1995 = mil novecientos...

04 Building block 2 - the hundreds (los cientos)

Number	Spanish	Phonetic	Note
100	cien / ciento	thyen / THYEN-to	cien alone; ciento before tens
200	doscientos	dos-THYEN-tos	
300	trescientos	tres-THYEN-tos	
400	cuatrocientos	kwa-tro-THYEN-tos	
500	quinientos	kee-NYEN-tos	IRREGULAR (not 'cincocientos')
600	seiscientos	seys-THYEN-tos	
700	setecientos	se-teh-THYEN-tos	IRREGULAR (not 'sietecientos')
800	ochocientos	o-cho-THYEN-tos	
900	novecientos	no-beh-THYEN-tos	IRREGULAR (not 'nuevecientos')

The three you must memorise: 500 quinientos, 700 setecientos, 900 novecientos. They do NOT follow the pattern. 900 (novecientos) is the one you need most: every 1900s year starts with it.

05 Building block 3 - the tens and the units

Tens	Spanish	Phonetic	Units	Spanish	Phonetic
10	diez	dyeth	1	uno	OO-no
20	veinte	BEYN-teh	2	dos	dos
30	treinta	TREYN-ta	3	tres	tres
40	cuarenta	kwa-REN-ta	4	cuatro	KWA-tro
50	cincuenta	theen-KWEN-ta	5	cinco	THEEN-ko
60	sesenta	seh-SEN-ta	6	seis	seys
70	setenta	seh-TEN-ta	7	siete	SYEH-teh
80	ochenta	o-CHEN-ta	8	ocho	O-cho
90	noventa	no-BEN-ta	9	nueve	NWEH-beh

Do not mix up noventa and novecientos: noventa (no-BEN-ta) = 90. novecientos (no-beh-THYEN-tos) = 900. 1990 needs BOTH: mil novecientos noventa.

06 The 'y' rule - the only place 'and' appears

y goes ONLY between the tens and the units: say y (ee, 'and') only between a ten and a unit: noventa y cinco. Never between thousands and hundreds, never between hundreds and tens.

Right: mil novecientos noventa y cinco. (y appears once, before cinco.)

Wrong: NOT 'mil y novecientos', NOT 'novecientos y noventa'. No y there.

Round tens take no y: 1980 = mil novecientos ochenta. No unit, so no y at all.

07 The 20s are written as one word

21 to 29 join up: unlike 31+, the twenties fuse into a single word with no y: veintiuno, veintidos, veintitres ... veintiseis, veintisiete.

This is why 2026 is easy: dos mil veintiseis = dos meel beyn-tee-SEYS. 2021 = dos mil veintiuno.

From 31 they split again: treinta y uno, cuarenta y dos, noventa y cinco. Three words, with the y back in.

08 Worked years - say these out loud

Year	Spanish (full)	Phonetic (stress in CAPS)
1066	mil sesenta y seis	meel seh-SEN-ta ee seys
1492	mil cuatrocientos noventa y dos	meel kwa-tro-THYEN-tos no-BEN-ta ee dos
1812	mil ochocientos doce	meel o-cho-THYEN-tos DO-theh
1939	mil novecientos treinta y nueve	meel no-beh-THYEN-tos TREYN-ta ee NWEH-beh

Year	Spanish (full)	Phonetic (stress in CAPS)
1975	mil novecientos setenta y cinco	meel no-beh-THYEN-tos seh-TEN-ta ee THEEN-ko
1980	mil novecientos ochenta	meel no-beh-THYEN-tos o-CHEN-ta
1990	mil novecientos noventa	meel no-beh-THYEN-tos no-BEN-ta
1995	mil novecientos noventa y cinco	meel no-beh-THYEN-tos no-BEN-ta ee THEEN-ko
1999	mil novecientos noventa y nueve	meel no-beh-THYEN-tos no-BEN-ta ee NWEH-beh
2000	dos mil	dos meel
2008	dos mil ocho	dos meel O-cho
2010	dos mil diez	dos meel dyeth
2026	dos mil veintiseis	dos meel beyn-tee-SEYS

09 Full dates - el [day] de [month] de [year]

The pattern: el + day number + de + month + de + year. el ocho de junio de dos mil veintiseis = the 8th of June 2026 (today).

Plain numbers, not 'th/st/nd': Spanish uses the ordinary cardinal: el ocho (not 'el octavo'). The one wobble is the 1st: Spain commonly says el uno de..., Latin America says el primero de...

Months are lowercase and never stressed in writing: junio, julio, enero. Phonetics below.

Month	Phonetic	Month	Phonetic
enero	eh-NEH-ro	julio	HOO-lyo
febrero	feh-BREH-ro	agosto	a-GOS-to
marzo	MAR-tho	septiembre	sep-TYEM-breh
abril	a-BREEL	octubre	ok-TOO-breh
mayo	MA-yo	noviembre	no-BYEM-breh
junio	HOO-nyo	diciembre	dee-THYEM-breh

Date	Spanish	Phonetic
8 Jun 2026	el ocho de junio de dos mil veintiseis	el O-cho deh HOO-nyo deh dos meel beyn-tee-SEYS
1 Jan 2000	el uno de enero de dos mil	el OO-no deh eh-NEH-ro deh dos meel
25 Dec 1995	el veinticinco de diciembre de mil novecientos noventa y cinco	el beyn-tee-THEEN-ko deh dee-THYEM-breh deh meel no-beh-THYEN-tos no-BEN-ta ee THEEN-ko

10 Asking and giving the date in conversation

Spanish	Phonetic	English
¿Que día es hoy?	keh DEE-a es oy	What day is it today?
¿A que estamos hoy?	a keh es-TA-mos oy	What's the date today? (very common in Spain)

Spanish	Phonetic	English
Estamos a ocho de junio.	es-TA-mos a O-cho deh HOO-nyo	It's the 8th of June.
Hoy es lunes.	oy es LOO-nos	Today is Monday.
Nacio en mil novecientos noventa y cinco.	na-THYO en meel no-beh-THYEN-tos no-BEN-ta ee THEEN-ko	He/she was born in 1995.
¿En que año naciste?	en keh AH-nyo na-THEES-teh	What year were you born?

11 Pronunciation traps

Spain th vs Latin America s: every 'c-before-e/i' and 'z' here is 'th' in Spain (Valencia register). In Latin America say the same words with a plain 's': cinco = SEEN-ko, doce = DO-seh, novecientos = no-beh-SYEN-tos. Same word, different sound.

v is never an English 'v': novecientos, veinte, nueve - the v/b is one soft sound made with both lips, closer to a gentle 'b'. Never bite your lip.

Don't invent the regular hundreds: it is quinientos / setecientos / novecientos, NOT 'cincocientos / sietecientos / nuevecientos'. These three are irregular.

The final -d in usted-style words is soft: and the z at the end of diez is a soft 'th', so diez sounds like 'dyeth', trailing off.

12 30-second cheat box

Years = one whole number: thousands + hundreds + tens + y + units. 1995 = mil novecientos noventa y cinco.

1900s: always start mil novecientos... (no-beh-THYEN-tos). Then add the tens and units.

2000s: always start dos mil... then just the rest. 2026 = dos mil veintiseis.

y only: between the ten and the unit (noventa y cinco). Nowhere else.

3 irregular hundreds: 500 quinientos, 700 setecientos, 900 novecientos.

Dates: el [number] de [month] de [year]. el ocho de junio de dos mil veintiseis.